

Buddhism: Quick Revision Sheet

Philosophy Optional Paper I - Indian Philosophy

Master Flow: Dukkha → craving → Pratīyasamutpāda → Anitya → Kṣaṇabhaṅgavāda → Anātmavāda → Nirvāṇa

UPSC Summary: Buddhism explains suffering through dependent origination, denies permanence through momentariness, and rejects a permanent soul through anātmavāda.

1. Core Definitions

Term	Meaning	Recall
Dukkha	Suffering, dissatisfaction, insecurity, and frustration caused by attachment to impermanent things.	Wider than physical pain.
Samudaya	Cause of suffering: craving or tṛṣṇā, supported by ignorance and attachment.	Cause is removable.
Nirodha	Cessation of suffering; liberation from craving and ignorance.	Makes Buddhism therapeutic.
Mārga	Path to cessation, especially the Eightfold Path.	Practical method.
Pratīyasamutpāda	Dependent origination: everything arises due to causes and conditions.	No independent essence.
Anitya	Impermanence: all conditioned things change.	Bridge to momentariness.
Kṣaṇabhaṅgavāda	Momentariness: things exist only moment by moment.	Continuity is a stream.
Anātmavāda	No permanent, independent, eternal self or soul.	Person exists conventionally.

2. Four Noble Truths - Disease Model

Analogy	Doctrine	Meaning
Disease	Dukkha	Life is marked by suffering and dissatisfaction.
Cause	Samudaya	Craving, ignorance, and attachment cause suffering.
Cure	Nirodha	Suffering ceases when causes cease.
Medicine	Mārga	Eightfold Path is the way to cessation.

Important: Buddhism is not pessimistic. It is realistic and therapeutic because it diagnoses suffering and provides a path to overcome it.

3. Doctrine Chain

Step	Doctrine	Logical Function
1	Four Noble Truths	Suffering has causes; therefore suffering can end.
2	Pratīyasamutpāda	All things arise dependently through causes and conditions.
3	Anitya	If things depend on changing conditions, they are impermanent.
4	Kṣaṇabhaṅgavāda	Impermanence is radicalized: things are momentary events.
5	Anātmavāda	If body and mind are momentary and conditioned, there is no permanent self.

4. Quick Answer-Writing Notes

Pratīyasamutpāda / Dependent Origination

- Nothing happens by itself; everything arises due to causes and conditions.
- Formula: This being, that arises; this ceasing, that ceases.
- Avoids eternalism and nihilism.
- Explains samudaya and nirodha.

Kṣaṇabhaṅgavāda / Momentariness

- All conditioned things arise, exist momentarily, and perish.
- Movie example: continuous appearance from separate frames.
- Continuity is a stream of momentary events.
- Supports impermanence and no-soul theory.

Anātmavāda / No-Self Doctrine

- Denies permanent, independent, eternal ātman.

- Does not deny the ordinary person completely.
- Person = conventional name for a changing combination of five skandhas.
- Dependent arising + momentariness imply no permanent self.

5. Five Skandhas

Skandha	Simple Meaning	Why It Matters
Rūpa	Body / material form	No permanent body; body changes.
Vedanā	Sensations / feelings	Pleasure and pain are changing experiences.
Saṃjñā	Perception / recognition	Identity is shaped by changing recognition.
Saṃskāra	Mental formations / tendencies	Habits and impulses are conditioned.
Vijñāna	Consciousness	Consciousness is a stream, not a fixed soul.

Memory Hook

Dependent arising → conditioned existence → impermanence → momentariness → no permanent self.

6. Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake	Correction
Calling Buddhism purely pessimistic	Write: Buddhism is realistic and therapeutic.
Saying Buddhism believes nothing exists	Write: Buddhism denies permanent independent essence, not conventional existence.
Confusing dukkha with only physical pain	Write: dukkha includes anxiety, dissatisfaction, insecurity, and existential suffering.
Explaining anātmavāda as total non-existence of person	Write: empirical person exists conventionally as a stream of five skandhas.
Forgetting links among doctrines	Connect dependent origination, momentariness, and no-self.

7. Ready-to-Use Answer Lines

- The Four Noble Truths make Buddhism therapeutic: they identify suffering, locate its cause, affirm cessation, and prescribe the path.
- Pratīyasamutpāda means all phenomena arise dependently; hence nothing has independent self-existence.
- Kṣaṇabhaṅgavāda holds that apparent continuity is only a stream of momentary events.
- Anātmavāda denies a permanent self, not the conventional empirical person.
- The five skandhas explain the person as a psycho-physical aggregate, not an eternal ātman.

Final 20-Second Recall

Dukkha has a cause. Since all things arise dependently, the cause can cease. Because conditioned things are impermanent and momentary, there is no permanent self. Liberation is possible by removing craving, ignorance, and attachment.